

the BRICS economy. Censorship would be a major issue since all the members of the BRICS group aren't exactly stalwarts of openness and fairness. China has an electronic great wall, Russia has its blacklist and India isn't that far behind at censoring information.

However, a few things could go wrong. The member nations are currently strictly monitoring the traffic passing through the cables, and since they seem to be the major stakeholders here it doesn't seem that's likely to change anytime soon. What will surely come into existence is another layer of firewalls blacklisting an even bigger set of websites all to which each of the member nations will contribute to going forward. All aspirations towards an open internet may continue to remain just that – hope.

This step of getting a second internet would be a bifurcation of the existing infrastructure but access will still be worldwide. Having a fallout between the member nations would result in further bifurcation and subsequently another layer of firewalls and undesirable monitoring. The end result would be the same as the geography we have – hundreds of mini internets (countries and states) connecting to a mega internet (continents). By the time the connection trickles down from halfway across the earth there's a possibility that what you'd be seeing would be half of what actually exists, with the remaining half getting "filtered".

"I believe there's a real chance that we can eliminate censorship and the possibility of censorship in a decade."

– Eric Schmidt (Google CEO)

Will it work?

Let's look at all the facets as we possibly can here. Laying a cable isn't out of the ordinary; there are already plenty of undersea cables. Also, it's not as if the cable laying is yet to begin, in fact, it's nearing completion and would become functional by mid-2015 which is six months away. There has been no lack of funds either, close to \$1.5 billion has already been invested for the cable laying project. So the majority of the infrastructure can be said to be ready by mid-2015.

Creating a second internet isn't a difficult prospect either given that the BRICS nations have the infrastructure and the spending power to do so. If motive is a concern then the snooping scandal was more than enough to get the ball rolling. So there wouldn't be a lack of countries willing to sign up for this initiative. This could be compared to what the Rothschild family managed to do over a hundred years ago. They had a wired telegraph infrastructure when the norm was to still use carrier pigeons. Their infrastructure was adopted across the country and it netted them quite some money.

The cable is 34,000 kilometers long and is connected to six countries with the option for others to join in. Each country maintains a section of the cable so each country/authority is held accountable for its own section. At the South African operator, the BRICS cable will be connected to two other cables which will run by the African continent's coast. So the cable will be accessible by the 21 African countries, which make up for a vast amount of untapped human and natural resources. So investors are more than happy to be getting an entry into a market at a time when a lot more will be joining in, thus putting everyone on an equal footing. At the end of the day, investing in the BRICS cable gains you access to a huge economy. Also, the individual investment needed by each country is reduced.

Splicing social networks into half isn't a new thing. As of now we do have Facebook privacy options wherein your profile is not visible to folks outside your friends'

network. A localised storage of data can be easily accomplished as the underlying scripts and programs are pretty much performing the splicing but on a different level. And servers exist everywhere – the only difference will be that these servers won't synchronise with the ones stored outside the region.

At the end of the day it seems like almost everything is in place, all that needs to be done is for the birthday kiddo to come and blow the candles.



There could be a lot more snooping if we aren't careful

Final say

Throughout history no one particular entity has been able to maintain monopoly over any resource. All it takes is time and some new player enters the market and knocks off the one of the top. The current internet administration may consist of a "group of nations" and that's about to change. The cable is nearing completion and with tempers flying high this might seem like a hurried move on the part of the BRICS. And it'd be wise to remember that this decision lies in the hands of politicians and as with any political process this could fall flat on its face. However, in the greater scheme of things it seems like a necessary move towards reducing the influence of the US and the UK over the traditional internet. And even though it's being kicked off on a small scale, it sure seems like more nations would opt in for the Second Internet. 